SAMPLE

# The Digital Designer

## Sell Design Skills in the Online Marketplace

Aiman Sterling

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1
putrabooks.github.io

## Introduction

Designers have one of the most monetizable skills in the digital economy. Every business needs design -- logos, websites, social media graphics, presentations, marketing materials, product packaging. The demand is endless.

But most designers limit themselves to one income model: client work. They trade hours for money, one project at a time, and their income is capped by the number of clients they can serve.

This book is about building multiple income streams from your design skills -- not just client work, but templates, assets, courses, and products that generate passive income alongside your active income.

Designers face two challenges:

**Income ceiling:** Client work is time-bound. You can only design so many logos, websites, or presentations per month. When you're full, you're full -- and growth stops.

**Passive income gap:** Designers create value every time they work, but that value is one-time. A logo design sold once earns once. The same design skills, applied to a template, can earn repeatedly -- but most designers don't know how to make that shift.

This book solves both challenges by showing you how to:

- Sell your design skills as services (active income).

- Package your designs as templates and assets (passive income).

- Teach your design skills through courses and tutorials (scalable income).

- Build a design brand that attracts clients and customers (compound income).

- **Graphic designers** who want to earn beyond client work.

- **Web designers** who want to create and sell templates.

- **Illustrators** who want to sell assets and prints.

- **UI/UX designers** who want to monetize their skills online.

- **Anyone with design skills** who wants to build multiple income streams.

- How to create and sell design templates.

- How to build a design asset portfolio.

- How to offer design as a service online.

- How to sell design courses or tutorials.

- How to use platforms like Creative Market, Envato, and Etsy.

- How to price design work for value, not hours.

- How to build a design brand that sells.

- A practical project: create and list one design product for sale.

Here's the principle: **your design skills are not just a service -- they're an inventory.**

Every design you create has the potential to be sold more than once. A logo concept can become a template. A color palette can become a design system. A tutorial can become a course. The same skills that earn you $50/hour in client work can earn $5,000/month in passive product sales -- if you know how to package them.

This book teaches you how to think like a designer-entrepreneur: creating once and selling repeatedly, building a portfolio of design products alongside your client services, and building a brand that makes both clients and customers come to you.

Let's start with the designer income model -- the framework for building multiple revenue streams from your skills.

The Designer Income Model

## Chapter 1: The Designer Income Model

A traditional designer earns from one source: client work. A designer-entrepreneur earns from multiple sources -- each with different characteristics, time requirements, and scalability. This chapter covers the 5 income streams available to designers and how they work together.

You design for clients -- logos, websites, branding, social media, marketing materials. You trade time for money, one project at a time.

**Income model:** Project-based or hourly. $500-$10,000+ per project.

**Time requirement:** High -- every project requires your active involvement.

**Scalability:** Low -- limited by your available hours.

**Best for:** Building your portfolio, generating immediate income, establishing your reputation.

You create templates once and sell them repeatedly. Social media templates, presentation templates, website themes, document templates, branding kits.

**Income model:** Per-sale. $10-$200 per template. Sell on Creative Market, Etsy, Gumroad, or your own site.

**Time requirement:** Low after creation. Create once, sell indefinitely.

**Scalability:** High -- infinite sales from one template.

**Best for:** Generating passive income from your most common design work.

You create design resources that other designers and non-designers buy. Fonts, icon packs, illustration sets, texture packs, UI kits, mockup packs.

**Income model:** Per-sale. $5-$50 per asset pack. Sell on Creative Market, Envato Elements, Design Cuts.

**Time requirement:** Low after creation.

**Scalability:** High -- infinite sales.

**Best for:** Monetizing your design assets that would otherwise sit unused.

You teach design skills through video courses, written tutorials, or live workshops. Create once, sell to many.

**Income model:** Per-course. $50-$500 per course. Sell on Udemy, Skillshare, Gumroad, or your own site.

**Time requirement:** Medium to create, low to maintain.

**Scalability:** Very high -- sell to unlimited students.

**Best for:** Leveraging your expertise into a scalable product. Building authority in your niche.

You create and sell your own branded products -- prints, merchandise, fonts, software tools, or design subscriptions.

**Income model:** Per-product or subscription. $10-$100+ per item, or $10-$50/month subscription.

**Time requirement:** Medium to create, ongoing to maintain.

**Scalability:** High -- limited only by your brand reach and audience size.

**Best for:** Building a design brand that generates long-term, recurring revenue.

The power of the designer income model is in combining multiple streams. No single stream is optimal alone:

- **Client services alone:** Good income, limited scalability. You work for every dollar.

- **Templates alone:** Passive income, but requires an audience to generate significant sales.

- **Courses alone:** Scalable income, but requires expertise and an audience.

- **Products alone:** Brand income, but requires marketing and fulfillment infrastructure.

**Combined:** Client services fund your living expenses while you build templates and courses. Templates generate passive income that covers your baseline. Courses establish your authority and attract more clients. Products build your brand and create recurring revenue.

| Stream | Monthly Revenue | Time Required | Type | | --- | --- | --- | --- | | Client services | $3,000-$8,000 | 30-40 hrs/week | Active | | Templates | $500-$2,000 | 5 hrs/month (maintenance) | Passive | | Assets | $200-$1,000 | 2 hrs/month (maintenance) | Passive | | Courses | $500-$3,000 | 5 hrs/month (marketing) | Scalable | | Products | $200-$1,500 | 5 hrs/month (maintenance) | Brand | | **Total** | **$4,400-$15,500** | **45-55 hrs/month** | **Mixed** |

The combined model generates more total income than client work alone, with less active time -- because passive and scalable streams contribute without proportional effort.

You don't build all 5 streams at once. Here's the recommended sequence:

- Build your portfolio with client work.

- Establish your reputation and style.

- Generate immediate income.

- **Timeline:** Ongoing from day 1.

- Identify your most common client deliverables.

- Turn them into templates.

- List on Creative Market, Gumroad, or your site.

- **Timeline:** 2-4 weeks to create and launch your first template.

- Identify design assets you create regularly (icons, illustrations, textures).

- Package them as asset packs.

- List on Creative Market, Envato Elements.

- **Timeline:** 1-2 weeks to create and launch.

- Identify what you teach clients most often.

- Create a mini-course (3-5 videos).

- Sell on Gumroad, Skillshare, or your site.

- **Timeline:** 2-4 weeks to create and launch.

- Build your design brand and audience.

- Create branded products (prints, fonts, subscription).

- Sell through your site and platforms.

- **Timeline:** 1-3 months to develop and launch.

Each income stream has its best platforms:

- **Creative Market:** The largest marketplace for design assets. 5-7 million buyers. 30% commission to the platform. Best for high-quality, professional design products.

- **Envato Elements:** Subscription-based platform. You earn per download. Good for high-volume, broadly appealing assets.

- **Etsy:** Good for printables, invitations, and craft-oriented design products. Lower per-sale price but large audience.

- **Gumroad:** Sell directly. You keep more per sale (10% fee) but need your own audience. Best for templates with a niche audience.

- **Your own site:** Highest margin (no platform fees) but requires traffic. Best once you have an audience.

- **Skillshare:** Free for students (subscription model). You earn per minute watched. Good for building an audience.

- **Udemy:** Large marketplace. You set the price (but Udemy discounts heavily). Good for volume.

- **Gumroad:** Sell directly. Higher price, smaller audience. Best for niche courses.

- **Your own site:** Highest margin. Best once you have an audience and email list.

- **Your own site:** Primary sales channel. Use Shopify, WooCommerce, or Gumroad.

- **Etsy:** For physical products (prints, merchandise).

- **Printful/Printify:** For print-on-demand products (t-shirts, mugs, prints).

- List which of the 5 income streams you're currently earning from.

- Which streams are you NOT using that could apply to your design work?

- For each stream you want to add, what's the first product you could create?

- Which platforms fit your products?

- Set a timeline: when will you launch your first template? Your first course?

- Calculate your target income from each stream over the next 12 months.

The designer income model transforms you from a freelancer into a design entrepreneur. Multiple income streams mean your earnings aren't capped by your hours -- and your design skills generate income even when you're not actively designing.

Creating and Selling Design Templates